

# Leave Policy

## Annual Leave Entitlement

Every full-time employee at Northwind Retail Corp. is entitled to 24 days of paid annual leave per calendar year, accrued at a rate of 2 days per completed month of service. Part-time employees accrue annual leave on a pro-rata basis according to their contracted weekly hours.

Annual leave accrues from the date of joining, but newly hired employees may not take more than 5 days of annual leave during their probation period without written approval from their department head.

## Leave Carry-Forward

Employees may carry forward a maximum of 8 unused annual leave days into the next calendar year. Carried-forward days must be used within the first quarter (January to March) of the new year, after which any remaining carried-forward balance is forfeited. Carry-forward requests above the 8-day cap require written approval from the department head and HR.

Carried-forward days are always consumed before the current year's fresh entitlement, so that the oldest balance expires first. Employees can view their carry-forward balance and its expiry date on the HR portal leave dashboard.

## Sick Leave

Employees are entitled to 12 days of paid sick leave per year. A medical certificate is required for sick leave exceeding 2 consecutive working days. Unused sick leave does not carry forward and is not encashed.

Sick leave may also be used to care for an immediate family member, subject to manager approval and capped at 4 days per calendar year out of the 12-day entitlement.

## Parental Leave

Birthing parents are entitled to 26 weeks of paid maternity leave, and non-birthing parents to 4 weeks of paid paternity leave, to be taken within 6 months of the child's birth or the date of adoption placement. Parental leave does not reduce the annual leave entitlement for that year.

Employees intending to take parental leave should notify HR at least 8 weeks before the expected start date so that cover arrangements can be planned with the reporting manager.

## Bereavement and Emergency Leave

Employees may take up to 5 days of paid bereavement leave on the death of an immediate family member (spouse, child, parent, or sibling), and up to 2 days for an extended family member. Bereavement leave is granted separately from annual and sick leave.

## **Unpaid Leave**

Unpaid leave of up to 30 consecutive days may be granted at the company's discretion once an employee has exhausted their annual leave balance. Requests require the endorsement of the department head and final approval from HR. Health insurance coverage continues during approved unpaid leave, but annual leave does not accrue for that period.

## **How to Apply for Leave**

Leave requests must be submitted through the HR portal at least 3 working days in advance for planned leave. Emergency leave should be reported to the employee's manager as soon as possible, with formal documentation submitted within 2 working days of returning to work.

Managers are expected to approve or decline a leave request within 2 working days of submission. If a request is not actioned within 5 working days it is escalated automatically to the department head.

## **Public Holidays**

Northwind Retail Corp. observes 12 public holidays per calendar year, published by HR each December for the year ahead. Employees required to work on a public holiday receive a compensatory day off, to be taken within 60 days of the holiday worked.